

JESSE LASTUNEN

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EXPERIENCE

- 2020–present **UNU-WIDER, THE UNITED NATIONS UNIVERSITY WORLD INSTITUTE FOR DEVELOPMENT ECONOMICS RESEARCH** HELSINKI, FINLAND
Research Associate • Research addressing policy challenges in the Global South, tax-benefit microsimulation modelling, training and capacity building (2020–); planning and oversight of activities in the SOUTHMOD programme, including research, contracts and events (2022–23); work to facilitate the use of AI across the organization and support for research on AI and labour markets (2023–)
- 2015–20 **RAND CORPORATION** SANTA MONICA, CALIFORNIA, UNITED STATES
Assistant Policy Researcher • Policy-oriented, interdisciplinary research for public sector clients
- 2017–18 **INTERNET ASSOCIATION** WASHINGTON D.C., UNITED STATES
Internet Economy Research Fellow • Research on the economic impact of autonomous vehicles
- 2016 **OECD, DIRECTORATE FOR SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY AND INNOVATION** PARIS, FRANCE
External Consultant • Research on the welfare gains of digital innovations for vulnerable groups
- 2014–15 **TECHNOPOLIS GROUP** TALLINN, ESTONIA
Consultant • Policy evaluation, data collection and analysis, funding proposals
- 2013 **PROJECT POLICY LTD** CAMBRIDGE, UNITED KINGDOM
Policy Researcher • Compiling, manipulating and analysing public socioeconomic data
- 2012 **BGATOR LTD** TAMPERE, FINLAND
Consultant • Ramping up international R&D projects, funding proposals, market research
- 2011 **CERN, THE EUROPEAN ORGANIZATION FOR NUCLEAR RESEARCH** GENEVA, SWITZERLAND
Researcher • Technology and market research, project funding, industry-science relations

EDUCATION

- 2015–20 **RAND SCHOOL OF PUBLIC POLICY**
Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Policy Analysis
Analytical concentrations in Economics and Quantitative Methods
Dissertation: “Technological Change and the Skill Premium: 21st Century Evidence”
- 2014–15 **UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO**
Doctoral Student, Fulbright Scholar in Public Policy (Political Economy and Statistics)
- 2013–14 **BARCELONA GRADUATE SCHOOL OF ECONOMICS**
Master’s Degree in Specialized Economic Analysis (Int’l Trade, Finance and Development)
- 2012–13 **UNIVERSITY OF CAMBRIDGE**
Master of Philosophy (M.Phil.) in Technology Policy • Graduated *with Distinction*
- 2011–12 **MASDAR INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY** IN COLLABORATION WITH **MIT**
Graduate Student in Engineering Systems and Management • *Certificate of Excellence*
- 2009–11 **TAMPERE UNIVERSITY OF TECHNOLOGY & UNIVERSITY OF TAMPERE**
Bachelor of Science (B.Sc.) in Industrial Engineering and Management • *Distinction*
Undergraduate Student in International Relations
- Other Courses and workshops in R, Python, STATA and Excel; data visualization; project management; scientific presentations; effective writing; randomized control trials; economic inequality; R&D evaluation; competency-based interviewing

ACTIVITIES

Professional service	UNU-WIDER Working Group on Artificial Intelligence, Chair, 2023– UNESCO Inclusive Policy Lab, Expert, 2023– Applied Economic Letters, International Tax and Public Finance, Routledge, Referee, 2023–
Teaching and mentoring	UNU-WIDER, Visiting PhD Fellowship Programme, Mentor for Basit Abdullah, Trang Thi Pham, Shakeba Foster, Kivamivi Gomado and Abdoul-Akim Wandaogo, 2021–24 RAND School of Public Policy, Teaching Assistant, Operations Research I, 2017
Media, blogs tools	Lastunen, J., Bayuo, B., Goriola, O. & Floyd, R. <i>Bridging Africa’s Data Gap with Synthetic Data and AI Tools</i>, WIDERAngle, UNU-WIDER, 2026. SISU Studio, an unofficial browser version for the Finnish microsimulation model, SISU, 2026–. Software for analysing microsimulation outputs: <i>UGAMOD-TAX</i>, 2024–; <i>SOUTHMOD</i>, 2025–. <i>SOUTHMOD Online Course on tax-benefit modelling for the Global South</i>, lead developer, 2024–. AI for economists: Prompts and resources, featured on the Marginal Revolution blog, 15 Jan 2024. Toppari, A. & Lastunen, J., <i>SOUTHMOD family extended: Welcome to the three new Latin American teams</i>, WIDERAngle, UNU-WIDER, 2023. Lastunen, J., Rattenhuber, B. & Oliveira, R.C., <i>The pandemic and Africa’s social safety net</i>, Project Syndicate, 2021. Oliveira, R.C., Rattenhuber, B. & Lastunen, J., <i>Efforts to protect the poor during COVID: How five African countries fared</i>, The Conversation, 2021. Remes, M., <i>Pandemia paljasti aukot turvaverkoissa</i>, commentary in Kehitys-Utveckling, a quarterly magazine produced by the Finnish Ministry for Foreign Affairs, no. 4/2021. Rattenhuber, B., Oliveira, R.C. & Lastunen, J., <i>Working together to better understand how COVID-19 affects poverty and inequality</i>, WIDERAngle, UNU-WIDER, 2021. Lastunen, J. & Rattenhuber, B., <i>Studying COVID-19 through the lens of microsimulation: The role of tax and benefit policies in alleviating poverty and inequality</i>, WIDERAngle, UNU-WIDER, 2020. Lastunen, J., <i>Politiikan tutkimuksen tulisi tarjota välineitä päättäjille</i>, Vieraskynä (op-ed), Helsingin Sanomat, 2014.
Short-term consulting	Czech Republic Technology Agency, evaluation methodology for an R&D funding program, 2013 Microsoft Research, business implications of changes in European privacy policy, 2013
Selected presentations 2021–	2025: III at 10th conference at LSE (London) • IIPF Annual Congress (Nairobi) 2024: <i>Empirical Research in the AI Era</i> workshop at the Bank of Portugal (Lisbon) • Webinar on AI for economists for the GESR Team at HM Treasury (online) • Session on AI and economics research at the UNU-WIDER research retreat (Helsinki) 2023: <i>Celebrating tax-benefit modelling: 50 years with LOTTE</i> conference (Oslo) 2022: IARIW-TNBS conference on <i>Measuring Income, Wealth and Well-being in Africa</i> (Arusha) • Global Development Conference (Clermont-Ferrand) • <i>Futures of Global Social Policy</i> workshop (Tampere) 2021: 6th Zurich Conference on Public Finance in Developing Countries • 8th World Congress of the International Microsimulation Association • International Centre for Economic Analysis Inequality conference • Development Studies Association’s <i>Unsettling Development</i> conference • 9th Meeting of the Society for the Study of Economic Inequality • Nordic Development Research Conference (all online) Multiple years: WIDER Development Conference (2021, 2023, 2025) • UNU Macau AI Conference (2024, 2025) • Microsimulation training events in Rwanda, Uganda and Vietnam (2022–) and online (2021–) • Annual SOUTHMOD Workshop (2021–26)

SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

Dissertation support	Emil Aaltonen Foundation Scholarship (2019) • Anne and James Rothenberg Dissertation Award (2018) • Alfred Kordelin Foundation Scholarship (2017) • American Scandinavian Foundation Scholarship (2016) • Finnish Foundation for Economic Education Scholarship (2015) • Yrjö Jahnsson Foundation Scholarship (2014)
Other scholarships	Fulbright Scholarship, University of Chicago (2013) • British Council Scholarship, University of Cambridge (2012)
Academic honours	Distinction, ranked first in class of 33 students, University of Cambridge (2013) • Certificate of Excellence for Outstanding Academic Performance, Masdar Institute (2012)

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

- Lastunen, J.** & Richiardi, M. *Forecasting Recovery from COVID-19 Using Financial Data: An Application to Viet Nam*, World Development Perspectives, Vol. 30, June 2023.
- Andrew, M., Marler, T. & **Lastunen, J.**, Acheson-Field, H. & Popper, S. *An Analysis of Education and Training Programs in Advanced Manufacturing Using Robotics*, RAND Corporation, 2020.
- Miller, B., Metz, D., Smith, T.D. & **Lastunen, J.** *Selecting and Evaluating Case Studies of the Economic Benefits of Research and Services at the National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health: Case Studies on Personal Dust Monitors for Coal Miners, Improved Ambulance Design, and Amputation Surveillance*, RAND Corporation, 2020.
- Miller, B., Metz, D., Smith, T.D., Landree, E., **Lastunen, J.** & Nelson, C. *Understanding the Economic Benefit Associated with Research and Services at the National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health: An Approach and Three Case Studies*, RAND Health Quarterly, Vol. 8(1), August 2018.
- Gehlhaus Carew, D., Martin, N., Blumenthal, M., Armour, P. & **Lastunen, J.** *The Potential Economic Value of Unlicensed Spectrum in the 5.9 GHz Frequency Band: Insights for Future Spectrum Allocation Policy*, RAND Corporation, 2018.
- Miller, B., Camm, F., Blumenthal, M., **Lastunen, J.** & Miller, K.W. *Inching Toward Reform: Trump's Deregulation and Its Implementation*, RAND Corporation, 2017.
- Silbergliitt, R., **Lastunen, J.**, Lauand, A., Watson, M. & Eusebi, C.A. *Wearable Technologies for Law Enforcement: Multi-functional Vest System Options*, RAND Corporation, Justice Policy Program, National Institute of Justice, 2017.
- Melin, G., Zuijdarn, F., Good, B., Angelis, J., Enberg, J., Fikkers, D.J., Puukka, J., Swenning, A., Kosk, K., **Lastunen, J.** & Zege, S. *Towards a Future Proof System for Higher Education and Research in Finland*, Publications of the Ministry of Education and Culture, 2015.

BOOK CHAPTERS

- Jara, H.X., Gasior, K., **Lastunen, J.** & Rattenhuber, P. *Tax-benefit Microsimulation Models in the Global South: The Experience of SAMOD, SOUTHMOD and EUROMOD-based Models for Latin America* (EUROMOD: 30 Years of the EU Tax-Benefit Microsimulation Model, edited by Figari, F. & Sutherland, H.). Springer Nature Switzerland AG, 2026, forthcoming.
- Lastunen, J.**, Nyssölä, M., Heimo, L., Karjanlahti, K. & Tiililä, N. *Talousshokit hyvinvoinnin haasteena* (Globaali Sosiaalipolitiikka, edited by Heimo, L. & Lambin, R.), Vastapaino, 2026.
- Lastunen, J.**, Shahir, A.A., Rattenhuber, P., Adu-Ababio, K. & Oliveira, R.C. *Performance of Tax-benefit Systems during the COVID-19 Pandemic in Sub-Saharan Africa: A Comparative Perspective* (Poor Protection: The Role of Taxes and Benefits in the Developing World During Crises, edited by Joust, J., Kanbur, R., Pirttilä, J. & Rattenhuber, P.), Oxford University Press, 2025.
- de Mahieu, A. & **Lastunen, J.** *The Cushioning Effects of Tax-benefit Policies in Viet Nam during the COVID-19 Pandemic* (Poor Protection: The Role of Taxes and Benefits in the Developing World During Crises, edited by Joust, J., Kanbur, R., Pirttilä, J. & Rattenhuber, P.), Oxford University Press, 2025.
- Oliveira, R., **Lastunen, J.**, Rattenhuber, P., Samarin, M. & Shahir, A.A. *The Role of Social Protection and Tax Policies in Cushioning Crisis Impacts on Income and Poverty in Low- and Middle-income Countries: A Rapid Scoping Review* (Poor Protection: The Role of Taxes and Benefits in the Developing World During Crises, edited by Joust, J., Kanbur, R., Pirttilä, J. & Rattenhuber, P.), Oxford University Press, 2025.

OTHER PUBLISHED WORKS

- Chang, R. & **Lastunen, J.** *Informal Consumption in the Microsimulation of VAT: Application to Rwanda, Peru, Mozambique, and Uganda*, WIDER Working Paper, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2026, forthcoming.
- Shahir, A.A. & **Lastunen, J.** *Electricity Tariff and VAT Reform in Ethiopia: Welfare, Poverty, and Cost-of-Living Spillovers*, WIDER Working Paper 2026/38, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2026.
- Kaidu, T., Okello Ayo, J., **Lastunen, J.**, Gasior, K. & Musoke, N. *SOUTHMOD Country Report Uganda: UGAMOD v3.0*, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2026.
- Rwagasana Shema, C. & **Lastunen, J.** *SOUTHMOD Country Report Rwanda: RWAMOD v2.0*, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2026; see also *SOUTHMOD Country Report Rwanda: RWAMOD v1.2 & RWAMOD v1.1*, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2025 & 2024.
- Tran, M.B. & **Lastunen, J.** *SOUTHMOD Country Report Viet Nam: VNMOD v3.5*, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2025; see also *SOUTHMOD Country Report Viet Nam: VNMOD v3.4*, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2024.
- Lastunen, J.**, de Mahieu, A., Jara, H.X., Gasior, K. & Pirttilä, J. *Microsimulation of Tax-benefit Systems in the Global South: A Comparative Assessment*, WIDER Working Paper 2024/35, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2024.
- Lastunen, J.**, Shahir, A.A., Rattenhuber, P., Adu-Ababio, K. & Oliveira, R.C. *Performance of Tax-benefit Systems amid COVID-19 Crises in Sub-Saharan Africa: A Comparative Perspective*, WIDER Working Paper 2023/130, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2023.

- de Mahieu, A. & **Lastunen, J.** *Addressing Poverty and Inequality in Viet Nam during the COVID-19 Pandemic: An Examination of the Alleviating Impact of Tax and Benefit Measures*, WIDER Working Paper 2023/120, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2023.
- Oliveira, R., **Lastunen, J.**, Rattenhuber, P., Samarin, M. & Shahir, A.A. *The Role of Social Protection and Tax Policies in Cushioning Crisis Impacts on Income and Poverty in Low- and Middle-income Countries: A Rapid Scoping Review*, WIDER Working Paper 2023/6. Helsinki: UNU-WIDER.
- de Mahieu, A., **Lastunen, J.**, Mukangango, J. & Harerimana, T. *Evaluating the Impact of the 2023–2024 Personal Income Tax Reform in Rwanda: An Analysis using Tax-benefit Microsimulation Modelling*, WIDER Working Paper 2023/73, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2023
- Hakizimana, N., Karangwa, J., **Lastunen, J.**, Nsabimana, A., Murasi, I., Niyigena, L., Noble, M. & Wright, G. *Tax-Benefit Microsimulation Model in Rwanda: A Feasibility Study*, WIDER Working Paper 2022/72, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2022.
- Wandaogo, A.-A., Sawadogo, F. & **Lastunen, J.** *Does the Adoption of Peer-to-government Mobile Payments Improve Tax Revenue Mobilization in Developing Countries?*, WIDER Working Paper 2022/18, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2022.
- Waiswa, R., **Lastunen, J.**, Wright, G., Noble, M., Okello Ayo, J., Isingoma, N.M., Kaidu, T., Kavuma, S., Arinaitwe, I., Mwesigye, M., Asimwe, W. & Rattenhuber, P. *An Assessment of Presumptive Tax in Uganda*, WIDER Working Paper 2021/163; *New Directions for Presumptive Tax in Uganda*, WIDER Policy Brief 2021/8, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2021.
- Lastunen, J.**, Rattenhuber, P., Adu-Ababio, K., Gasior, K., Jara, X.H., Jousté, M., McLennan, D., Nichelatti, E., Oliveira, R.C., Pirttilä, J., Richiardi, M. & Wright, G. *The Mitigating Role of Tax and Benefit Rescue Packages for Poverty and Inequality in Africa amid the COVID-19 Pandemic*, WIDER Working Paper 2021/148, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2021.
- Lastunen, J.**, Wright, G., Noble, M., Waiswa, R., Okello Ayo, J. & Isingoma, N.M. *Distributional Effects of the COVID-19 Pandemic in Uganda*, WIDER Policy Brief 2021/5, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2021.
- Lastunen, J.** *Technological Change and the Skill Premium: 21st Century Evidence*, doctoral dissertation, Pardee RAND Graduate School, 2020. Published by the RAND Corporation (RGSDA1167-1), 2021.
- Lastunen, J.** *Scenarios of the Role of Autonomous Vehicles in Society: Estimating the Net Impact on Professional Driving Jobs*, research report and invited talk, Internet Association, 2018.

TECHNICAL NOTES

- Lastunen, J.**, Dietrich, S., Rattenhuber, P., Adu-Ababio, K., Baah, P., Goriola, O. & Bayuo, B. *Synthetic Data and AI in Microsimulation Models: A Feasibility Study using GHAMOD*, WIDER Technical Note 2026/2, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2026.
- Kaidu, T., **Lastunen, J.**, Noble, M. & Okello Ayo, J. *UGAMOD-TAX: A Microsimulation Model of Taxation in Uganda: Model and Data Documentation*, WIDER Technical Note 2025/3, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2025.
- Noble, M. & **Lastunen, J.** *Dealing with the Oversimulation of Taxes and Benefits in SOUTHMOD Microsimulation Models: The Case of Givinka in Rwanda*, WIDER Technical Note 2023/2, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2023.
- Lastunen, J.** *On-model Adjustment of Incomes During COVID-19 in SOUTHMOD Tax-benefit Microsimulation Models*, WIDER Technical Note 2022/4, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2022.
- Oliveira, R.C., **Lastunen, J.**, Nichelatti, E. & Rattenhuber, P. *Imputation Methods for Adjusting SOUTHMOD Input Data to Income Losses Due to the COVID-19 Crisis*, WIDER Technical Note 2021/19, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2021.
- Gasior, K., Barnes, H., Jousté, M., **Lastunen, J.**, McLennan, D., Noble, M., Oliveira, R.C., Rattenhuber, P. & Wright, G. *Full-Year Adjustment for Modelling COVID-19 Policies in SOUTHMOD Tax-Benefit Microsimulation Models*, WIDER Technical Note 2021/18, Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2021.
- Lastunen, J.** *Deriving Shocks to Household Consumption Expenditures from the Associated Income Shocks Resulting From COVID-19*, WIDER Technical Note 2021/16. Helsinki: UNU-WIDER, 2021.
- Chen, J., Kumar, K.B., **Lastunen, J.**, Nataraj, S., Nowak, S. & Carter, P. *Modeling Outcomes Based on Inequality in Labor Earnings: Model Overview and Policy Experiments*, a report describing a general equilibrium model on the U.S. labour market, RAND Corporation, 2017.

RESEARCH ASSISTANCE

- National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine, *Advancing Automated and Connected Vehicles: Policy and Planning Strategies for State and Local Transportation Agencies*, Research Report 845, Washington, DC: The National Academies, 2017.
- OECD, *Making Innovation Benefit All: Policies for Inclusive Growth*, OECD Publishing, Paris, 2017.